

Owen Manley

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Professor Ghazaleh

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Overview of “Revolution OS” & Letter By Richard Stallman

“Revolution OS” was a movie comprising the founding fathers of GNU/Linux and how their ideologies brought people to form a community as well as make pivotal discoveries/contributions that will have an everlasting impact on the world of software. Furthermore, over the 20+ years that it took to develop Linux, it was an arduous process that brought together communities, divided programmers between different philosophies, and caused uproar as Linux became the foundation of computer systems as well as later iterations of that system in the modern era. Although it was individuals such as Richard Stallman & Linus Torvalds who started the movement in the 1980s, if not for the contributions of other programmers, computer systems would not be as successful as they are today. In fact, most computer systems would likely still be in a primitive state, and not as advanced as they are now.

Development of Linux began with Stallman and implementation of his philosophy integrated into his new operating system. Stallman had never used Unix and only used it when he wanted to make a free iteration because he did not agree with what Unix stood for. In addition, the new operating system in development (GNU System), allowed more freedom with the user whereas Unix’s system was more restricted. Moreover, the GNU system allowed the freedom to run for any purpose, allowed the ability to study how the program worked/make changes to compute what the user wants, and allowed the redistribution of copies to others. Not only does it

grant redistribution, but the ability to redistribute modified copies to others permitted communities to form who concurred with one another to continue modifications.

Eventually, the term “open source” was thrown around to identify a new philosophy within the free software movement by Richard Stallman, no less. Beginning in the 1990s, the open source movement combatted the beliefs of the idea of free software because even though they were similar at a first glance, there are small differences that make the two software ideologies distinct from one another. Open source software still allowed the freedom to manipulate its source code, distribute it to others, and share manipulated copies to others; however, the licensing can prohibit it from having the same level of freedom as free software. Thus, the difference between free software/ open source is that while free software prioritizes freedom, open source focuses on practicality and the code not being accessible to the general public.

In conclusion, Revolution OS was a movie comprising the founding fathers of GNU/Linux and how their ideologies brought people to form a community as well as make pivotal discoveries/contributions on software. Richard Stallman began his journey on what he believed to be right by developing an operating system that could be tweaked, distributed to others, and modified versions being able to be distributed as well. Then, open source as a philosophy began to take hold of the free software community because of its distinct, subtle differences. Open source software allowed the same freedoms as free software did but only to a certain audience prioritizing code-quality and collaboration over accessibility to the general public. Without Stallman’s GNU system & Linus Torvald’s “Linux kernel”, computer systems would not be as advanced as they are now in the modern era and the world has them to thank for the work that they put in to make computing an experience for everyone to enjoy.

